

Vote Millers Early Favorite In Association

The 57th American Assn. baseball season officially opens tonight with Minneapolis an early favorite to oust the champion Wichita Braves for the league title.

Wichita led the Millers, 9 to 8, in a baseball writers poll for first place, but stronger backing for runner-up honors gave Minneapolis a total of 152 points to 147 for the Braves.

The remaining first place ballots went to Denver (3), Omaha (1), and St. Paul (1).

The league's four southern clubs play host to northern members tonight with St. Paul at Charleston, Denver at Indianapolis, Minneapolis at Louisville, and Omaha at Wichita. The northern teams will make a six-day, two-city road trip before their home openers April 22.

Since the close of the 1957 campaign, there have been four changes in the managerial order, two in major league affiliation, and one in the makeup of the association directorate.

Andy Cohen, manager at Denver from 1951 through 1954, returned to the Grizzley helm when Ralph Houk accepted a Yankee coaching job after three seasons with Denver.

Indianapolis, with whom Cohen served in 1957, has the famed National League catcher, Walker Cooper, as player-manager.

Succeeding Dutch Meyer at Louisville was another ex-receiver, Del Wilber, who has scouted since the close of his big league playing career in 1954.

Gene Mauch, who spent the 1957 season as an active member of the Boston Red Sox, will double as the Minneapolis manager and second baseman. He replaced Red Davis.

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